

THE TRUST PARADOX

Why behaviour, not belief, determines trust and how
leaders can bridge the trust gap to drive performance

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I INTRODUCTION



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At Investors in People, our purpose is simple: Make Work Better. And that starts with one thing - trust. It sounds easy, but as the research in this whitepaper shows, it's anything but.

Trust is the foundation of any organisation, the platform on which everything is built. It is the most powerful lever a leader has, the ultimate strategic enabler. With it, you drive engagement, ownership and buy-in from your people. Without it, all you have is a plan on a piece of paper.

This research draws on how employees and HR leaders perceive and approach trust in the workplace, conducted via Censuwide. Leaders understand the value of trust, and there's considerable evidence linking it to stronger organisational performance. But how trust actually plays out day-to-day, how it shows up in the behaviour of employees and leaders, is far less clear.

With organisations going through significant amounts of change and employees feeling the pinch (as explored in our last whitepaper Finding the Frequency), we set out to explore the story employee behaviour tells about trust today in organisations.

You will find the full results throughout this paper, but in short, we found a clear rhetoric-reality gap between how people perceive trust and how they actually demonstrate it. HR leaders may feel confident that their leaders are

creating high trust cultures, but with employees routinely 'covering' themselves at work, hiding their mistakes and refusing to speak up about important issues, is that confidence misplaced?

With organisations chasing much-needed productivity gains in a complex and volatile environment, fixing this gap is critical. No one can afford the wasted energy employees appear to be spending on defensive behaviours, while innovation and growth cannot thrive sustainably in an environment where people are reluctant to speak up. And because trust is dynamic, not static, the alignment between words and actions can quickly shift it - for better or for worse.

Creating trust and transparency sits at the heart of Investors in People's framework and is foundational to the leadership needed in today's challenging world. Organisations that thrive will be those where leaders are trusted at every level, where people feel empowered to challenge the status quo, and where a culture of trust and ownership is genuinely lived.

We hope this paper supports you, as people leaders, to reflect on how trust shows up in everyday interactions, how your people experience it, and how, even in challenging times, you can strengthen behaviours and processes at every level to build greater trust and, ultimately, stronger performance.

82% of HR leaders believe employees are trusted **BUT**
61% of employees regularly "cover themselves" **AND**
65% avoid speaking openly at work

KEY INSIGHTS FOR PEOPLE LEADERS

1

Trust impacts performance

Employees (93%) and HR leaders (100%) alike say trust is important at work. Trust is linked to performance, with 48% of HR leaders concerned that low trust in teams impacts productivity and 37% believing it leads to lower engagement. Low trust drives employee defensiveness and disengagement, with only 7% of employees saying it wouldn't impact how they behave at work.

2

There is a rhetoric-reality gap between trust and behaviours

While employee perceptions of trust within their organisations are relatively positive (a third say people are trusted unless they give reason not to be), this is undermined by ubiquitous defensive employee behaviours. Some 61% of people admit to regularly 'covering' themselves at work, with 32% doing it most weeks.

3

Employees are not speaking up

Around two-thirds (65%) of employees have avoided raising or speaking openly about something at work in the last six months, most commonly over concerns around workload or manager behaviour. A quarter of employees would try and fix a problem or mistake at work before telling anyone.

4

Low trust weakens commitment

One in five employees say low trust at work has weakened their commitment to their organisation. Low trust drives employees to disengage: three in 10 say it leads them to focus on protecting themselves, a quarter that they do only what is required and about a fifth that it would lead them to look for another job.

5

Managers influence trust...

...But manager capability is mixed. One in five employees say trust in their organisation depends heavily on who your manager is. The same proportion have felt reticent about speaking up about concerns over manager behaviour in their organisation.

6

Leaders aren't walking the walk

C-level leaders are more likely to cover up their mistakes, with a third (33%) not speaking up about mistakes they have made at work - more than twice as likely than the average employee. With role modelling and vulnerability a key part of building psychological safety, how many leaders are failing to walk the walk?

WHY TRUST MATTERS

In his landmark 2006 book *The Speed of Trust*, leadership guru Stephen Covey writes: “Low trust slows everything – every decision, every communication, and every relationship.” It’s a truism many HR professionals will likely be painfully aware of, with a ringside seat to how trust between employees, leaders and managers supports or obstructs organisational goals.

And research by neuroscientist Paul Zak, published in *Harvard Business Review* in 2017¹, lays out a business case for building trust at work that is hard to argue with. According to Zak’s research, compared with people employed at low-trust companies, people in high-trust companies report 74% less stress, 106% more energy at work, 50% higher productivity, 13% fewer sick days, 76% more engagement and 40% less burnout.

A recent CIPD evidence review on trust and psychological safety² further confirms that trust is an organisational, not just cultural, priority. “Trust and psychological safety are linked to a wide range of positive outcomes,” the report says. “These include individual attitudes, team behaviours and environment, and overall performance.”

NEUROSCIENCE RESEARCH FINDS PEOPLE IN HIGH-TRUST COMPANIES REPORT:

- 74% less stress
- 106% more energy at work
- 50% higher productivity
- 13% fewer sick days
- 76% more engagement
- 40% less burnout

Source: Paul Zak, *Harvard Business Review*

“Trust matters in organisations,” confirms academic and expert on trust Veronica Hope Hailey, emeritus professor at the University of Bath’s School of Management. “If you don’t have it, the organisation becomes dysfunctional and ineffective.” Trust is particularly valuable, she adds, in times of uncertainty, and can help people buy into and engage with change and transformation, something most organisations are going through right now.

External drivers like ongoing geopolitical chaos, economic uncertainty and cost-of-living pressures and the exponential yet destination-unknown rise of AI mean the trust people have in their employer is more valuable than ever. Yet it appears to be more fragile too. Established measurements like the Edelman Trust Barometer³, now in its 25th year of measuring trust levels globally across a range of institutions, has noted over the past few years that public trust in institutions including businesses is declining. Hope Hailey says organisations and leaders find themselves “swimming in a sea of distrust”, which can stymie organisational progress.

And with Gallup’s most recent State of the Global Workplace report⁴ finding that employee engagement in the UK is sitting at just 10%, with 46% of the workforce saying they feel stress every day at work, there is clearly a burning platform to focus on trust as a route to achieving more positive workplace experiences.

Against this backdrop, Investors in People set out to investigate how trust is playing out in practice across British businesses. As our previous whitepaper *Finding the Frequency*⁵ explored, organisations are undergoing significant amounts of change and employees are feeling the pinch (one in four people have considered leaving their roles due to the amount of change they are experiencing and one in five feels worn down by change). Given that context, do organisational HR teams and leaders really understand how trust is impacting performance and showing up through employee behaviours, and how to move the dial on the things that matter most?

To find out Investors in People surveyed more than 1000 employees and 500 HR leaders. You’ll find the results throughout this paper.

WHAT WE MEAN WHEN WE TALK ABOUT TRUST

Trust at work is not a single thing. In this paper, we use trust to mean three distinct but connected concepts. They are:

- **Trust is a feeling:** The extent to which any individual feels safe and supported at work.
- **Trustworthiness is a characteristic of leaders and organisations:** The qualities that make them deserving of trust. A useful model is: ability, integrity, benevolence and predictability.

➤ **Trusting behaviour:** This is what people actually do when trust is present or absent, speaking up or staying silent, covering themselves or taking risks, committing or holding back.

While related and often interdependent, these three are not the same. Employees can feel broadly positive about their organisation and still exhibit defensive behaviours, for instance. The response to each dimension may differ, as we will explore.



EXPERT VOICE

TOM FOLEY is Lead Human Intelligence for Performance Specialist at Leading Edge Performance. He has a background in match officiating in rugby, including as Television Match Official at the 2023 Rugby World Cup Final.

In organisations, trust isn’t optional: it’s foundational. It’s the operating condition that makes high performance possible. Whether a team is high performing or not doesn’t come down to capability or intelligence, it comes down to how people feel. When trust is present, you can quickly correct behaviour and steer people in the right direction. But when it isn’t, even good decisions become difficult to land because there’s a lack of understanding and trust in what you’re trying to do.

Trust is about behaviours rather than intent. It is built when behaviours are consistent, when leaders are transparent, candid and build psychological safety where people feel they can speak up. If people are scared of conflict, consequences or even looking silly, they stay silent – and performance suffers.

There are trust mechanics and trust organics. Trust mechanics don’t require skill. It’s about following through on what you say, setting clear expectations and being transparent: those are simple to execute and don’t require any skill. Trust organics are more complicated and require high emotional intelligence. It requires speaking to a person rather than a role and building human-to-human connection. The role of a leader is to manage the trust barometer through a combination of trust mechanics and trust organics.

Trust comes down to saying what you’re going to do and then doing it. Behaviours flow through the organisation far quicker than decisions. Seemingly small things count and are noticed by employees. In one organisation I worked with, the dishwasher in the kitchen had been broken for a while. Employees told me: ‘If we can’t even trust them [leaders] to fix the dishwasher, how can we trust them on bigger decisions?’

“Trust is the operating condition that makes high performance possible”

When trust is damaged, it’s important for leaders to acknowledge the reality and understand what’s not working. Next steps are around restoring predictability. Broken trust will often feel like inconsistency, so rebuild it by resetting standards, and following through. Often leaders try and over-explain, but more information is not necessarily better. It’s about the content and coming back to the legitimacy of what you are saying and doing, not what you’re telling people you are doing.

A CHALLENGING CONTEXT: EMERGING TRUST ISSUES

With the context in which we all work shifting fast, and being continually buffeted by external geopolitical and socioeconomic forces beyond our control, trust becomes both more important and more fragile. Work does not exist within a vacuum. HR professionals and leaders must be aware of more emerging issues that can either bolster or diminish trust. Taking a step back and creating a holistic picture of these drivers helps build understanding of how trust today can be won or lost.

↘ **Growing insularity and polarisation:**

The Edelman Trust Barometer 2026⁶ warns leaders of a “crisis of insularity”. The research says that 70% of people worldwide now have an insular mindset, meaning they are unwilling or hesitant to trust someone with different values, facts, problem-solving approaches or from a different cultural background.

↘ **Hybrid working and return to office (RTO) mandates:**

Rigid RTO mandates can erode trust and engagement. Whether intentional or not, they signal a lack of trust in employees and an inability to manage based on outcomes, both of which undermine the goal they purport to seek, increasing connection and performance.

↘ **The rise of AI:**

AI is already changing work fast, and we are only at the start of what’s possible. Widespread employee anxiety – a recent study from the Pew Research Center found 52% of US workers are worried about the future impact of AI in the workplace⁷ – is not a stable foundation for building trust. Aside from concerns over job stability, employees are uneasy about how AI is being used in HR processes and decision-making and around inequality of access to tools and training. According to Mercer’s 2026 Global Talent Trends⁸, 72% of employees believe some employees in their organisation have better access to AI tools and training than others.

↘ **Surveillance and monitoring:**

The rise of employee monitoring software (like tracking keystrokes, screen time or location) is a significant, growing trust issue. Harvard Business Review⁹ notes that employee surveillance erodes trust and leads to employees being more likely to engage in counterproductive behaviour in response to being monitored.

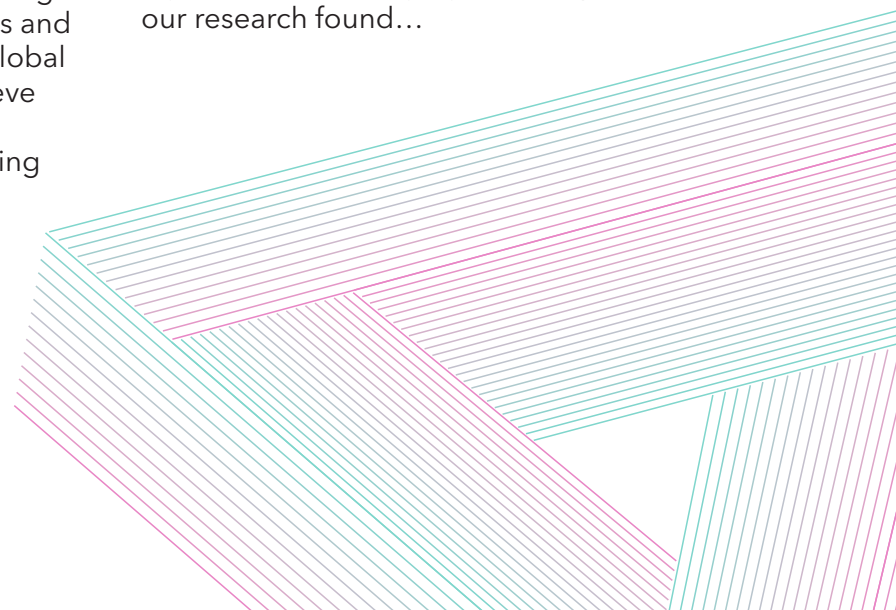
↘ **Cost of living pressures:**

Financial stress outside of work erodes the psychological safety that underpins trust at work. PwC’s 2025 Global Workforce Hopes and Fears Survey¹⁰ found that 55% of workers globally were experiencing financial strain. Those under financial pressure were less likely to trust their manager or feel cared about.

↘ **Change fatigue and uncertainty:**

As explored in our previous whitepaper, a significant proportion of the UK workforce is feeling burned out by organisational change. With many organisations reducing headcount and restructuring, both fears over job loss and the survivors’ guilt effect post-redundancy can threaten trust levels.

Against this challenging backdrop, here is what our research found...



TRUST: THE RHETORIC-REALITY GAP

According to our survey, employees and HR leaders alike firmly believe that trust is important at work. Almost all (93%) employees say trust is important at work, and 29% say it's essential. Among HR leaders, 100% say trust is important, with 55% elevating it to the status of essential. Trust is seen to drive performance, with nearly half (48%) of HR leaders saying when trust is low within teams they are concerned about reduced productivity, and 37% about lower engagement. They are right to be concerned, as only 7% of employees say that low trust in the organisation or its leadership wouldn't impact their behaviour.

TRUST IS IMPORTANT AT WORK

100% HR leaders agree
93% of employees agree

TRUST IS ESSENTIAL AT WORK

55% HR leaders agree
29% of employees agree

When it comes to trust levels at work, our research - on the surface at least - seems relatively positive. Most HR leaders (82%) believe their people are completely or mostly trusted to use their judgement at work, and 72% of employees believe they are either completely or mostly trusted in their role.

A third (32%) of employees say that within their organisation people are trusted unless they give reason not to be, while 37% of HR leaders agree this is the case within their organisation. However, one in five people say trust depends heavily on who your manager happens to be, and one in 10 say trust at their organisation is talked about more than practised.

Dig a little deeper however, and employee behaviour signals a trust paradox, with the reality of day-to-day behaviour not what you would expect from a high-trust culture and undermining the confidence HR professionals feel in how psychologically safe people feel at work. Defensive behaviours are rife.

HR LEADERS ON THE PERFORMANCE IMPACT OF LOW TRUST...

When trust is low in teams, what impacts concern you most?

48% Reduced productivity
37% Lower engagement
25% People avoiding accountability
22% Higher turnover
21% Fewer ideas or innovation
20% Incomplete work/missed deadlines
16% Loss of discretionary effort
1% No most concerning impacts

While 49% of HR leaders say employees raise issues early when things go wrong, a quarter of employees say they would try and fix a problem or mistake at work before telling anyone about it. Some 61% of people admit to regularly 'covering' themselves at work (for example by keeping emails or screenshots), with a third (32%) of employees doing it most weeks. Only 9% of people say they never cover themselves at work.

WHICH BEST DESCRIBES HOW TRUST OPERATES DAY-TO-DAY WHERE YOU WORK?

Legend
Employee HR

People are trusted unless they give reason not to be



People have to earn trust before being given autonomy:



Trust depends heavily on your manager:



Trust is talked about more than practised:



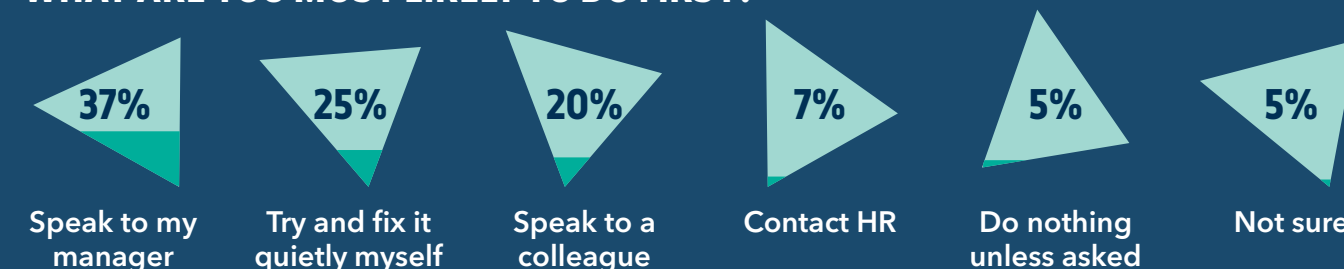
There is low trust with people protecting themselves rather than collaborating:



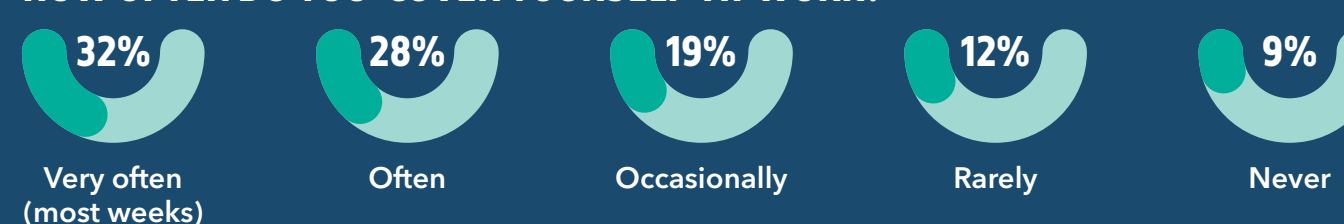
Prefer not to say:



WHEN SOMETHING GOES WRONG AT WORK, WHAT ARE YOU MOST LIKELY TO DO FIRST?



HOW OFTEN DO YOU 'COVER YOURSELF' AT WORK?



TOP 5 most commonly avoided areas

- 1 Concerns about workload or burnout
- 2 Concerns about management behaviour
- 3 Disagreement with decisions
- 4 Ideas that challenge current ways of working
- 5 Organisational change

65%

of employees have avoided raising or speaking openly about something at work in the last six months.

Speaking up is a key component of trust. As Megan Reitz, associate fellow at Saïd Business School, Oxford University and adjunct professor of leadership and dialogue at Hult International Business School, puts it: "Trust enables people to speak up with things that matter, and to listen when people have spoken up." But when it comes to speaking up, we find that about two-thirds (65%) of employees have avoided raising or speaking openly about something at work, most commonly concerns over workload and burnout or manager behaviour. Does this really signal high-trust organisational cultures?

We also find that trust impacts commitment at work and that low trust drives behaviours most leaders would want to avoid. Positively, a quarter of employees (27%) say trust has strengthened their commitment to their organisation. However, one in five employees say low trust has weakened their commitment to their organisation, rising to a quarter (26%) among those aged 25 to 34, perhaps because of the often-reported shifting expectations of Gen Z workers. For a small yet still worrying group, the impact is even worse: 8% of employees say they are actively considering leaving their organisation due to trust issues.

Concerningly, we also find HR professionals are experiencing low trust at work significantly more than those in other professions. More than half (52%) of HR respondents say that a lack of trust at work has weakened their commitment to the organisation. It does not seem too much of a stretch to infer this could be because of HR's exposure to and knowledge of poor leadership behaviour.

Low trust has an impact on employee behaviours, causing employees to disengage and protect themselves: three in 10 say it leads them to focus on protecting themselves and a quarter that they only do what is required. One in five say it would drive them to look for another job or to stop taking initiative – but more hearteningly, the same proportion say it would drive them to try and step up to make a positive difference.

THE IMPACT OF LOW TRUST AT WORK

ONE IN FIVE employees say trust at work has weakened their commitment to their organisation

When trust in leadership or the organisation is low, employees are most likely to...



EXPERT VOICE

VERONICA HOPE HAILEY is emeritus professor at the School of Management, University of Bath. She is an expert in trust and trustworthy leadership, and the author of a series of reports with the CIPD researching the impact of the pandemic on responsible business, leadership and trust.

Trust matters in organisations. If you don't have it, the organisation becomes dysfunctional and ineffective. Research shows that without trust, decision-making takes longer and innovation and agility decrease. However, if you have high trust, innovation, problem sharing and solving and knowledge sharing increase, and people are more willing to take leaps of faith and roll with change. Trust is particularly valuable in times of uncertainty and ambiguity.

The decision of whether to trust is made up of three things. One is the propensity of any individual to trust – some people are more trusting than others, and if someone has had a breach of trust in one workplace, they will carry that into other workplaces. The second thing is motivation: can I trust this employer or organisation, and am I motivated to do so? With an institution like the NHS, for instance, trust in its procedures and policies really matter, as our life may be in its hands.

The third aspect is the trustworthiness of the person or institution in whom they're asking to put their trust. Can I trust this employer or this organisation? How much does my life depend on them? Research shows that the four key pillars of trustworthiness are ability, benevolence, integrity and predictability.

One of the problems we have at the moment is that employers are swimming in a sea of distrust. The Edelman Trust Barometer shows a decline in trust in institutions: people are not disposed to trust institutions, and employers can be seen as institutions. Another aspect of life today impacting trust is the rise of social media. It has created an unsafe climate, with people wary of showing any vulnerability at all.

My recent research, working with national institutions, has slightly changed my thinking on trust. We have been putting so much emphasis on trustworthy leadership and interpersonal trust, but we also need to think about institutional trust: the extent to which people trust in the systems, structures and policies in organisations. An institution has to demonstrate trustworthiness in the way it organises itself. For employees, leadership behaviour matters, but HR policies and systems must be fair and trustworthy themselves. For customers, how an institution shows up with its structures, systems and policies really matters as our relationship tends to be more with an institution than an individual.

"Leadership behaviour matters, but an organisation also has to demonstrate trustworthiness in the way it organises itself."

This really matters as we are going into a world which is going to be dominated by AI. That means HR leaders need to think again about policies, structures and decision-making through a lens of justice, fairness, transparency and integrity. You need both institutional trust and individual relational trust: they've got to come together for you to get a high trust environment.

TRUST, LEADERSHIP AND MANAGEMENT CAPABILITY

As explored in detail in a previous Investors in People whitepaper¹¹, managers matter hugely to someone's experience of work, with 93% of employees saying that management was important to their overall job satisfaction.

When looking at trust specifically, we find the same is true: managers have an outsized influence on trust. Reitz confirms this: "When asking people to reflect on psychologically safe cultures, their frame of reference is often their manager. The manager relationship is therefore incredibly important in developing trust within the organisation." But when management capability across the vast majority of organisations is mixed (something most HR professionals will recognise), what impact does that have on trust?

It is encouraging that more than a third (37%) of employees say they would first speak to a manager if something went wrong at work, compared to the 25% who would try to fix it quietly alone and 20% who would speak to a colleague. This is a positive signal of trust in managers in some cases, but it is by no means universal. One in five employees say that trust in their organisation depends heavily on who your manager happens to be, and the same proportion say they have felt reticent around speaking up about poor manager behaviour in their organisation.

Our data also finds that leaders are not walking the walk when it comes to psychological safety. While many organisations espouse rhetoric around failing fast and learning from mistakes as critical to innovation, this does not appear to be playing out through leadership behaviour in many cases. We find that C-suite leaders are surprisingly likely to cover up their mistakes rather than speaking about them openly. When asked if they had avoided speaking up about anything at work in the last six months, 33% of executive level respondents said they had avoided speaking up about mistakes they had made at work (compared to 14% across all employees).

This suggests that despite messages around leaders role modelling humility and not having all the answers (something that is key to building psychologically safe cultures), many leaders are not walking the walk. With more than a third (37%) of HR leaders citing poor leadership behaviour as the biggest near-term risk to trust, addressing the rhetoric-reality gap, or the gap between intention and reality, must be a core priority when it comes to building high-trust cultures.

WHEN IT COMES TO TRUST, MANAGEMENT MATTERS

ONE IN FIVE employees say trust in their organisation is heavily dependent on who their manager is.

ONE IN FIVE employees have avoided speaking up about concerns about manager behaviour at work

HR leaders' top 3 near-term risks to trust

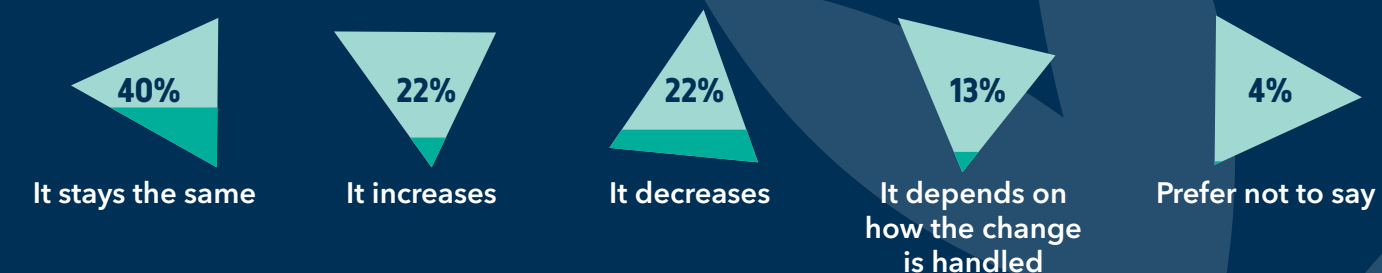
- 37%** Poor leadership behaviour
- 29%** Inconsistent communications during time of uncertainty
- 26%** Inconsistent manager capability

How leaders communicate change can have a major impact on trust, for good or ill. We find room for improvement here: for 42% of employees, important decisions that affect their role or team are either announced with limited explanation (18%), shared after decisions are final (12%) or not communicated directly (12%). While 22% of employees say their personal trust in leadership increases during periods of organisational change, the same proportion say it decreases.

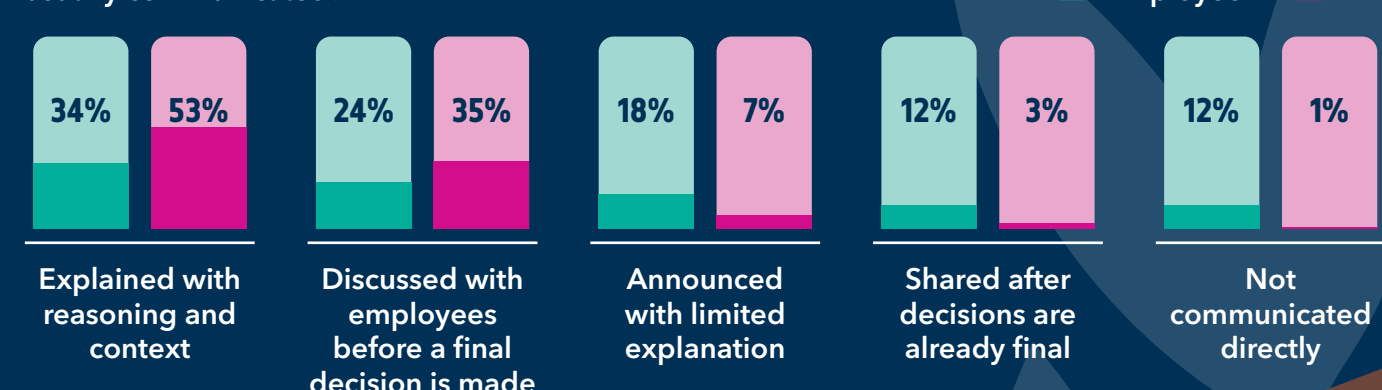
There is also a gap between HR perception and employee reality here. More than half (53%) of HR leaders believe decisions around change are explained with reasoning and context, compared to 34% of employees. And 35% of HR leaders say potential changes are discussed with employees before final decisions are made – something only 24% of employees recognise.

COMMUNICATIONS AND TRUST

During periods of organisational change, how is your personal trust in leadership typically affected?



When decisions affect employees' roles or teams, how are they usually communicated?





EXPERT VOICE

MEGAN REITZ is associate fellow at Saïd Business School, Oxford University and adjunct professor of leadership and dialogue at Hult International Business School. An expert in how people interact with each other at work, she is the author of books including *Speak Out, Listen Up: How to have conversations that matter*.

Trust enables people to speak up with things that matter, and to listen when people have spoken up. Our habits around what we say and who we hear define everything from ethical conduct to innovation, engagement and performance.

We have surveyed nearly 25,000 employees globally on their habits around speaking up and listening. One clear pattern is that as you get more senior, you believe the environment is more psychologically safe than it actually is.

A psychologically safe environment is one where teams can have tricky conversations, necessary for performance, in a sustainable way. It's not one where everyone is necessarily feeling comfortable. One sign of a psychologically safe team is actually when it's a bit uncomfortable, because people are having those tricky conversations. When asking people to reflect about psychologically safe cultures, their frame of reference is often their manager. The manager relationship is therefore incredibly important in developing trust within the organisation.

"We need to create the spaces where we see one another as human beings"

Our organisational systems are more task-focused than ever. Measures of success focus on activity, and trust, and the conversations that build it, often gets missed out of the equation. Whilst we need to be in the 'doing mode' to achieve results, we also need to create the spaces where we see one another as human beings, where we can open up more expansive, spacious attention.

Use the SPACE acronym to open up more spacious attention within organisations that are pathologically busy:

- 👉 **Safety:** When we are anxious, our attention narrows and we become more self-interested. Psychological safety frees up people's attention so they can focus more fully on relationships and listening to others.
- 👉 **People:** We are greatly influenced by the people we surround ourselves with. As far as is possible, surround yourself with those that help you create space to look up, look out and engage with different perspectives.
- 👉 **Attention:** We can train our attention and how we show up as leaders. Mindfulness techniques can rewire the brain and 'speed bumps', which are intentional breaks to slow down rushed behaviour, can enable us to check and choose our attention. Small things, like introducing a pause at the start of meetings so people can think how they want to show up, can make a huge difference in developing trust.
- 👉 **Conflict:** Purposefully engage with people and situations that allow you to engage with different perspectives and challenge your view of the world.
- 👉 **Environment:** Environment makes a difference to how we pay attention to one another. Walking meetings, for example, can develop a different level of trust, if it helps you to change the way you have the conversation.

We have to pay attention to the small conversations to allow the big ones to happen. Those small spaces that might not feel important or efficient are the glue that holds the system together. If you squeeze them out, the whole thing will collapse.



BRIDGING THE RHETORIC- REALITY GAP: PRACTICAL RECOMMENDATIONS

Investors in People practitioner Liam Linacre sums up the paradox organisations face around trust perfectly when he says: “The real challenge and the real opportunity is that many organisations don’t actually know how trusted they are. Often, they assume trust because the language of trust is present. But trust isn’t declared; it’s experienced. It shows up in the micro-moments: how leaders respond to challenge, how transparent communication really is, how people feel when decisions are made about them rather than with them.”

And as our data clearly shows, while the language of trust may be present in many organisations, with leaders and HR teams believing they have created a high trust culture, the behaviour of many employees simply does not back this up. Defensive, covering behaviours and an unwillingness to speak up about mistakes made, workload or poor manager behaviour among a significant proportion of employees show how critical it is for leaders to bridge the rhetoric-reality gap when it comes to trust. But how?

Based on expert input, insights from Investors in People’s practitioner community, and our research, here is where to start when it comes to building trust, and sustaining it through change and uncertainty.

BUILDING TRUST

Foundational recommendations for starting from scratch or strengthening existing culture

1 Measure, don’t assume, trust

Trust is dynamic and lives through the everyday behaviours of the organisation. Measuring trust robustly is a prerequisite for improving it. Yet our survey found that the most common method HR professionals use to gauge trust is manager feedback, cited by 51%. Given management capability is highly variable, this source is unreliable on its own. HR professionals should combine multiple data sources, including pulse surveys with questions designed to surface trust-related behaviours, exit interview analysis, indicators like rates of escalation, speaking up and error reporting. And be aware that those in more senior positions tend to perceive the culture as more psychologically safe than those below them.

2 Equip managers to build trust

Investors in People’s research has consistently found managers have a huge impact on how people experience work day-to-day. Trust is no different, and as it is the foundation on which organisation performance is built, manager capability must be front and centre. IIP practitioner Lindsey Waters says

investing in manager development around empathy, self-awareness, conflict resolution and communication goes a long way. “Help managers understand how small, daily interactions can either build or erode trust,” she advises. “Managers who understand their own behavioural habits are far better positioned to empower others.”

3 Encourage leaders to role model vulnerability

Leaders are key to building psychological safety, but our data finds they are the most likely group to cover up their mistakes at work. Trust grows when leaders are willing to share their vulnerabilities. HR should encourage leaders to model openness and transparency, about their own learnings and in speaking about the organisation more widely, rather than presenting as overly polished. IIP practitioner Richard Budd has worked with one organisation where leaders include an “epic fails” slide in their monthly updates, talking to teams about what’s gone wrong and how they’ve learned from it. Such an approach sends a powerful message about the acceptability of failure.

4 Bake trust into HR processes

As academic and trust expert Veronica Hope Hailey reflects, trust must be baked into HR processes, with institutional trust as essential as leadership trust. This is even more pertinent in the age of AI, with many HR systems becoming increasingly automated. Systems and processes must be reviewed through a lens of fairness and trust, mitigating the risk of bias. AI use should be fair and transparent: when AI is used in HR processes without employees understanding how, it can feel opaque and unfair, undermining institutional trust.

SUSTAINING TRUST

How to sustain what you’ve built when in motion, through change and uncertainty

1 Create the conditions for speaking up

Building a speak-up culture requires leaders to actively signal that challenge is welcome and demonstrate this through how they respond. Megan Reitz research finds that as leaders become more senior, the gap between how safe they think employees feel to speak up and how employees actually feel is often wider than leaders realise. Use a mix of channels such as anonymous feedback mechanisms, listening groups and skip-level meetings (1:1 meetings between leaders and an employee who reports to their direct report). Consider the dynamics in any room. “If senior leaders are present, conversations can quickly turn into ‘ask the manager’ sessions,” Waters says. “Try reframing them as opportunities to ‘tell the manager’ instead.”

2 Involve people early in decision-making

“Nothing erodes trust faster than decisions that feel imposed,” says Linacre. Our data finds that this is happening in a significant number of organisations, with employees not being consulted on decision-making. “Bringing employees into the conversation before decisions are final reduces self-orientation and builds shared ownership,” Linacre adds.

3 Give clarity

Ambiguity erodes trust. When people don’t know what’s expected of them or where the organisation is going, they fill in the gaps, often driven by anxiety. Yet in a fast-shifting, complex environment, clarity can be hard to sustain.

The answer, says performance expert Tom Foley, is not in over-explaining: “More information is not necessarily better. It’s about the content and coming back to the legitimacy of what you are saying and doing.” Clarity means being specific about outcomes and being honest about what isn’t certain. Budd recommends giving people explicit clarity on how their role connects to organisational strategy, using tools like OKRs or shorter sprint cycles to make accountability and direction more tangible.

4 Give space for relationships

Academic and psychological safety expert Megan Reitz speaks of the importance of giving space for human-to-human connection and relationship building. This can be crowded out through the operational stresses of work, but losing it risks weakening the relational foundations trust is built on. HR professionals and leaders should treat relationship-building as an organisational priority, deliberately designing it in. This could be via structured informal time, check-ins at the start of meetings or encouraging cross-team connections.

5 Focus on consistency and make it visible

Predictability is core to trust: people have to believe leaders will do what they say they will. Close the loop on turning feedback into action (or explaining why action is not possible or realistic, if that is the case). And make it visible. “Trust grows when people see leaders follow through,” Linacre advises. “Simple say-do check-ins help teams stay accountable and strengthen reliability.”

Of course, sometimes trust becomes damaged, even broken. Read on for insight from people leaders on how to repair broken trust, as well as more detail on how to build high trust cultures...

Investors in People Practitioner Q&A: BUILDING, SUSTAINING AND REPAIRING TRUST

Three leaders from Investors in People's vibrant practitioner community share their top tips on how people professionals can help build trust in organisations.



What impact does trust have on organisational performance?

Liam Linacre (LL): When trust is present, people lean in. They offer ideas without fear of judgement. They take ownership because they believe their contribution matters. They navigate uncertainty with more resilience because they trust the intent behind decisions, even when those decisions are tough. Performance lifts not because people are pushed harder, but because they feel safe enough to give more of themselves.

Lindsey Waters (LW): Trust is the quiet force that makes everything else work. When it's low, people hold back. You see higher turnover, more absenteeism, lower engagement, dips in wellbeing and a reluctance to stretch or contribute beyond the basics. All of that has a direct financial impact: hidden costs that rarely show up on a spreadsheet but hit the bottom line. But when you prioritise trust and psychological safety, the organisation starts to feel like a movement – aligned, energised and moving in the same direction.

Richard Budd (RB): Trust is vital to stronger business performance. If we can get trust, you see greater engagement and people feel more motivated. Part of that is people understanding how their role contributes to the business, having that link between the purpose and how they contribute. Trust is also linked to collaboration and togetherness, the ability for people to look at ideas and lessons learned, make decisions at pace and feel autonomy within their role.

How can HR professionals build high-trust cultures?

LL: Building trust is about shaping the everyday experience of work. HR doesn't own that, but it shapes the ecosystem where trust can grow. Practical tips include encouraging leaders to lead with honesty rather than perfection; creating emotionally safe spaces where leaders can listen without defensiveness and respond with empathy; and developing leaders who lead with humanity. Use the elements of the Trust Equation, which frames trust as a balance of four elements: Credibility (what leaders say), Reliability (what leaders do), Intimacy (how safe people feel) and Self-Orientation (whether a leader is acting in their own or others' interests).

LW: Building a high-trust culture isn't about one big initiative. It's the result of lots of intentional actions that make people feel safe, heard, and valued. Practical starting points include giving people safe and inclusive spaces to share their thoughts, remembering that not everyone is comfortable speaking up in the same way. Be sure to close the loop on any feedback given: showing that you've listened builds trust; ignoring it is one of the fastest ways to lose it. Equip managers to be builders of trust, encouraging them to create regular, structured check-ins that feel personal rather than purely performance-driven. And combine meaningful human connection with reliable data, supplementing survey data with face-to-face qualitative insight to get a clearer picture of where trust is strong and where it might be breaking down.

RB: The key is involving everyone in the strategy and how they play their part in delivering it. The best organisations are very transparent about plans, sprints and OKRs. Don't act in silos: the more everyone understands about each other's roles and objectives, the more interconnected the business will become. Encourage managers and leaders to speak openly about when things haven't gone to plan, make feedback loops easier and encourage challenge at all levels. Humans have a reluctance to trust people at first sight, and trust is built on relationships, so think about what you are doing to bring people together across the business.

How should HR professionals tackle broken trust?

LL: When trust breaks, it rarely happens in a single moment. It's usually the result of small fractures that have gone unaddressed. The instinct can be to fix it quickly, but trust doesn't respond to speed: it responds to sincerity, transparency and behavioural consistency. Start by naming the reality: honesty begins to shift the emotional climate. Listen before acting, identify the behavioural root causes and co-create a visible path forward. It's important to communicate with transparency, even when the message is tough and to model the behaviours you want leaders to adapt. Rebuilding trust takes time and patience: treat it as a process, not an event.

LW: Rebuilding trust isn't just about correcting leadership behaviour: it's about how everyone in the organisation shows up. Trust is a two-way relationship, and a culture of trust is shaped collectively through everyday interactions, not just strategic statements. One of the most powerful places to begin is by grounding the organisation back in its core values, creating clarity and alignment. Increasing senior leader visibility is essential: people want to see leaders in real, human interactions. People can quickly detect when communication is overly managed; it's more effective when leaders share openly what's happening, why decisions were made and what comes next. Create structured opportunities for genuine feedback, safe ways for voices to be heard again. This could be anonymous feedback channels, facilitated group discussions or regular listening sessions: anything that shows the organisation wants to hear the truth.

RB: Hierarchy is often the starting point and what's broken. If leaders are getting involved in the day-to-day operations, feeling like they are experts, they need to start thinking differently about how they are positioning themselves. We need to trust our people to deliver and use their expertise to shape how we are doing things. Think differently about the organisational structure, creating a circle where you can see how people link together and building safe spaces for people to have conversations. Ask yourself: how does the organisation work? Have you got a parent-child approach, or a collaborative approach where people are treated as equals and adults? Very often, when trust is a bit broken, the culture is parent-child. Leaders might feel they are helping people, but they are actually suffocating them.



CONCLUSION: BUILDING TRUST TO DRIVE PERFORMANCE

Building trust at work isn't about polished rhetoric or grand gestures, but about the behaviours that shape the everyday experiences of work. It lives or dies by how a leader responds when something goes wrong, whether people feel safe to raise concerns, whether what's promised is actually delivered.

Our research finds a gap in many organisations between the rhetoric around trust and how employees are showing up through their behaviours and in their relationships. This risks harming cultures and impacting performance and productivity, if employees are more focused on defensive behaviours like hiding their mistakes or concerns than contributing to the purpose and goals of the organisation.

Trust is dynamic not static. Building and maintaining it is an ongoing process, not a one-off event. It lives through human-to-human interactions, behaviours at all levels and in the fairness of institutional systems and processes. HR professionals cannot own it, but they can contribute meaningfully to building the foundations that enable trust to grow, and through that drive sustainable, powerful organisational performance.





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Case study: BI Worldwide

BUILDING TRUST THROUGH EMPLOYEE EMPOWERMENT

When Andrea Rowe joined recognition, incentive and events company BI Worldwide as people and culture director, she asked Investors in People to assess the organisation. One standout and concerning finding was that trust and trust in leadership was low. So, Rowe set out to fix it.

The first step was to listen. Rowe ran sessions across the organisation to hear people's experiences of working at the firm firsthand, and gain insight into what was working well and less well. One common complaint was people only being told "good news stories", Rowe recalls – "being told everything was rainbows and unicorns, and not believing it." Other surfaced issues included a culture of overwork, a lack of transparency over core data like salary levels and people not feeling comfortable about speaking up if something had gone wrong or in challenging behaviours that didn't align to values.

"There was an unspoken feeling of not being comfortable or empowered to challenge," says Rowe. "There wasn't a feedback culture, so nobody knew how they were doing." That extended to a lack of clarity over performance management, with managers unwilling to be honest with people about under-performance. There was, in short Rowe says, "a breakdown of trust". People also didn't trust that sharing their thoughts, via surveys for example, would lead to change.

To boost trust, Rowe introduced a 'culture champions' initiative, with culture champions in each team given responsibility for surveying their colleagues and talking through the results. While Rowe oversaw this, she crucially removed herself from the process itself. "I wanted to be detached, leaving it to people who had trust within the

teams," she explains. "It wasn't necessarily managers, but people who had a passion for the culture of the organisation and wanted to see things improve."

Other actions included working with the CEO on communications approaches. "When the CEO is giving messages, people want to know whether it's good, bad or ugly," Rowe says. "They want to know our strategy and vision. And they want to understand how what they do feeds into the bigger picture."



Performance management processes were revamped into a more regular conversational cadence, with a focus on feedback. "People weren't consistently getting timely feedback from their managers," Rowe says. "I don't believe in having just one end-of-year performance review. It needs to be happening all the time."

People across the business have been trained in how to give feedback in a respectful and constructive way. "I wanted to equip people not only to give feedback, but to be able to have conversations if they saw something that doesn't align with our values," Rowe explains. "We've given a framework that helps take the emotion out of feedback." And introducing affinity groups, based on employee demand, is helping create psychologically safe spaces for different groups to come together, have open conversations and engage with leaders.

As a result of this work, BI Worldwide has achieved Investors in People Gold accreditation, and is reaping the benefits across a range of people and business metrics. Attrition is down, as is sickness absence, and customer NPS scores have risen. Rowe notes that working on building trust has helped reset relationships between employees and employer from parent-child to adult-adult. "Now people are coming to us not with problems, but with solutions. Empowering people is what encourages innovation."

"Now people are coming to us not with problems, but with solutions. Empowering people is what encourages innovation."



ROWE'S TOP TIPS

- Listen first to build a picture of employee concerns, experiences of work and ideas for improvement.
- Engage with and empower employees to lead on building trust, rather than directing everything from a leadership level.
- Be honest and transparent in leadership communications and give people clarity on their role in supporting organisational strategy and vision.
- Equip people at all levels to give and receive feedback in a constructive, respectful way.
- Build a cadence of regular performance feedback so people understand expectations.

Case study: Fortem Solutions

LEADERSHIP LISTENING AND LEARNING IN ACTION

When workers at property solutions company Fortem show up to a property to carry out repairs, they don't always know who will answer the door. "It might be a someone elderly or it might be someone very vulnerable" says chief operating officer Chris Tredget. That makes trusting people's judgement, both in how they do the job itself and handle at-times challenging circumstances, absolutely vital.

Fortem is responsible for the upkeep of thousands of homes across the UK on behalf of local authorities and social housing association landlords. Since he joined the company in 2024, Tredget has made empowerment and trust central to leadership.

In his first meeting with his senior leadership team, he set out his stall clearly, focusing on the value of and expectations around empowerment. "It was important to get the senior leadership acting as a team, talking across silos, and resolving wider issues" he says. "If you get the decisions made at the right level by the right people, you get better outcomes more quickly."

Alongside starting the empowerment conversation, training was rolled out to boost leaders' self-awareness via personality profiling, 360-degree feedback and other tools, helping them understand their strengths, weaknesses and impact on others. "It's an intense thing for people to go through," Tredget admits. "But when you get out the other side, with a truly empowered senior leadership team, you find fewer issues coming to the board for resolution."

A new strategy was created in workshops with the leadership team - "it was important they owed it" - along with work around vision, mission and behaviours. To launch the strategy to the wider business, Tredget held a inspirational launch event and, together with other directors, visited every office, including those no director had visited before, and ran a series of presentations for representatives from all parts of the business.



To improve internal communications, monthly video updates were introduced. "We keep the communications open, honest and humorous where we can, and are transparent about the good and the bad," says Tredget. A central Blue Book of standardised processes was created, allowing those doing the work day-to-day to update how work gets done and to share lessons learnt. To date, 200 changes and improvements have been made, improving efficiency and supporting high quality delivery of services.

A trades group was created to get feedback on what wasn't working from a frontline worker perspective. "Initially, it was me talking and them listening, until they worked out they could trust us," Tredget says. Identifying quick fixes to show their input made a difference, and that leadership was listening was key. One example was reducing how often people were required to take photos of their vans before starting a job - "a better way of demonstrating you don't trust someone, I don't know," Tredget points out.

"We keep the communications open, honest and humorous where we can, and are transparent about the good and the bad"



Ensuring people feel safe enough to share and learn from mistakes collectively is vital to trust. In Tredget's previous organisation, a construction worker dug through a gas main, shutting down a village's supply just before Christmas. Rather than reprimanding the person responsible, they were invited to share what they'd learned at other sites. "Similar incidents dropped by 70% because he'd made it personal," says Tredget. "We all make mistakes, I've made plenty, but it's how we learn from them and tell stories across the business so we collectively learn from them."

Fortem's focus on empowerment has evidently paid off. Attrition has halved, profitability has increased and engagement scores have reached a 20-year high of 92%. The company has achieved Investors in People Gold accreditation and 81% of employees feel confident to challenge behaviours not aligned with the company values.

TREDGET'S TOP TIPS

- Read the book or watch YouTube clips on Turn the Ship Around by former Navy captain David Marquet to open up a conversation about how empowerment works in your organisation with your senior management team.
- Empower people to make decisions and unknott problems at all levels, reducing issues and challenges coming up the business structure.
- Empower those doing the job day-to-day to make process improvements and share them across the business.
- Look for quick changes you can make to demonstrate that leadership is listening.
- When things go wrong, focus on storytelling around lessons learned rather than reprimanding those involved.

Case study: Gunning London

UNLOCKING THE KEYS TO PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

As a small, family-owned business where many people have decades-long personal relationships, construction and refurbishment firm Gunning London has both unique opportunities and challenges when it comes to building and sustaining trust. “You’ve got this core base of very strong relationships, but when someone new comes in, they might not look at things from the same standpoint: their trust equation will be different,” says the firm’s people lead Gary Inman.

There is a difference, he adds, between trusting someone “because I’ve worked with them for years and he’s a great bloke” and trusting someone because of their level of professional competency. And this can sometimes present a challenge in terms of creating psychologically safe spaces where everyone feels they can speak up.

Another challenge is how increasing professionalisation impacts on trust, for example bringing in new talent with specific professional skillsets to fill roles that may have previously been covered by multi-tasking, long-term employees. “The trust is there, but it’s tested continually by every new situation, new piece of software, new challenge, new learning,” Inman reflects.

When it comes to creating stronger psychological safety, Inman is focused on consistency (“you can’t just say ‘we have a no blame culture’ once: you have to mention it constantly”) and believes systems matter as much as relationships. “We’ve leant into systems and processes, which could sound counterintuitive,” he says. “But providing clarity over job roles and workflows brings a level of psychological safety with it.”

Building in consistent check-ins and dashboards that give transparency over operations and performance helps build this psychological safety: “The more data-driven you are, then the more you can talk about improving processes.” And focusing on systems and processes rather than individual failure when something goes wrong is also key. “It’s not whether you failed or let me down: we’re always looking at how we can make the process better first, which makes it easier to talk about,” Inman explains.



Not all small businesses are able or choose to invest in strategic HR or business coaching support, but Inman is clear that doing so can put them in a far stronger position to focus on strengthening culture, and therefore trust. Part of this comes from the ability of a senior HR expert to challenge leadership where needed and lean into at-times difficult conversations, acting as a critical friend to leaders across the business.

“Most small organisations would have hired someone to cover recruitment and grievances, operational HR, but [building and sustaining trust] is high level, tricky stuff,” Inman explains. “Who is going to tell you that you’re damaging trust, or that people aren’t telling you things? Who is picking that up, and then how do you handle it?”

With the world continuing to change fast (Inman cites the rise of AI in particular as a trend that will impact on trust significantly), trust requires constant attention. “New situations will come up all the time to test trust in ways that haven’t been tested yet,” he says. But for Gunning so far, the focus on building trust has paid off in terms of business performance. Bidding processes have improved and the company continues to grow. “If you were to write a list of all the things leaders have to be good at to optimise organisational performance, you could knock quite a few off without it being terminal,” Inman concludes. “But if you don’t engender trust and psychological safety, that is a massive barrier that is much harder to fix.”

“You can’t just say ‘we have a no blame culture’ once: you have to mention it constantly.”



INMAN’S TOP TIPS

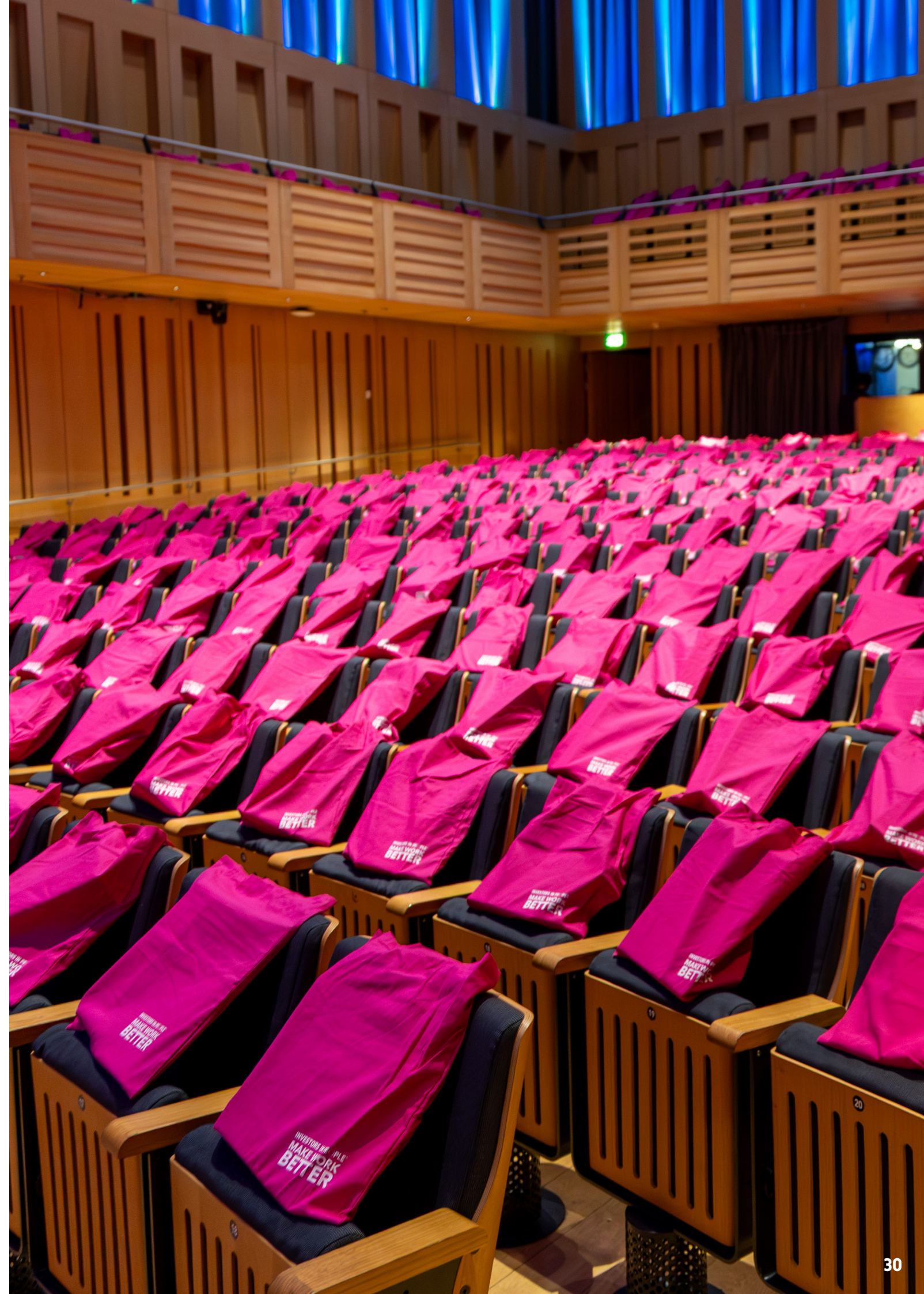
- Engage senior or coaching HR support where possible to speak truth to power around building and sustaining trust.
- Provide clarity through systems, processes, structures and roles.
- When something goes wrong, focus on improving the system rather than apportioning individual blame.
- Ensure that both the successes and failures of change are openly communicated.
- View building and sustaining trust as a continuous and dynamic project, never taking your eye off the ball.

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Why Investors in People

EVERY CHALLENGE IN THIS REPORT IS ONE WE'RE BUILT TO SOLVE.

Attraction. Retention. Engagement. Leadership capability. Productivity. Wellbeing. These aren't new problems, but they're getting harder to ignore. And for most organisations, the gap between knowing what needs to change and actually changing it is where progress stalls.

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When people are disengaged

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When leadership isn't landing

Our practitioners work alongside your leaders to close the gap between intent and impact - building the capability that drives performance from the top down.

When retention is a revolving door

Organisations accredited by Investors in People don't just attract better candidates - they build cultures people choose to stay in. That's not a by-product of accreditation. It's the point of it.

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2

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3

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4

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Investors in People is a Community Interest Company and an agent of change, calling for a movement that puts people first - for the benefit of every person in every workplace, increased productivity across organisations, and a stronger, healthier and happier society.

Investors in People was established in 1991 by the UK government as a standard for best people practice. Building on this heritage, today we're a proud Community Interest Company with one purpose: to **MAKE WORK BETTER** for individuals, organisations, and society.

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80% of IIP Accredited Organisations state that they can Attract Quality Applicants

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More than just a structure, our frameworks provide a rigorous yet supportive approach, helping us test, challenge, and recognise outstanding people practices within organisations. We bring them to life through staff discussions and surveys, ensuring that every assessment reflects real voices rather than a mere tick-box exercise.

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85% of IIP accredited organisations confirm they have a Motivated & Engaged Workforce

EXPERT-LED SUPPORT

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Simply put, we work hard to help organisations get the most out of their people, unlocking potential, strengthening culture, and driving measurable success.



80% of IIP Accredited Organisations report a Positive Impact on Quality of Leadership



80% in our community report a Positive Impact on Staff Wellbeing

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Our diverse community of organisations share a commitment to putting people first, creating workplaces that inspire, and driving success for employees, customers, and organisations alike.

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